

“One Of The **BEST PLACES** To Be Right Now **IS** The **ELECTRONICS INDUSTRY**”

Willis Langford

HR director, Avnet



Most electronics engineers give up on core electronics jobs because they have no idea about the skillsets required, or key factors that a company looks for. Willis Langford, HR director, Avnet, tackles these issues by sharing his views on the hiring trends in Avnet and the electronics industry today, in an interaction with Ankita KS

Q. Is quality talent a challenge that electronics design players are facing or will face in India?

A. One of the growing concerns of employers at large is that India produces engineers by the day. The question, however, remains: how many are employable? This scenario is no different in the electronics industry where incumbents often seem more inclined towards IT, management and commerce. With the Internet of Things (IoT) positions blossoming, there would soon be a correction to this trend.

Q. What are the skillsets required for key trends with respect to IoT jobs?

A. With the IoT segment growing rapidly, specialised skills in data security, connectivity, business intelligence, networking, remote access development and hardware optimisation are the most sought after. Individuals with a reasonable design background and passion for transforming any conventional business to be more competitive will be the ones to succeed.

Q. The IoT is an amalgamation of electronics, datacom and IT. Out of these three, which will be the Achilles heel for the IoT sector in terms of ready availability of good talent pool?

A. Electronics, datacom and IT will continue to be pursued. However, an abundance of IT in the market could well be the low-hanging fruit for any organisation to leverage. For long-lasting results, electronics will continue to be the base.

Q. What is your advice to professionals working in electronics or IT sector and eyeing a role in the IoT space?

A. They should strive to upskill themselves by adding IoT skillsets. Due to the nature of the IoT, these topics will become a segment within the ecosystem

covered by the IoT. So to move up the value chain, candidates should step up their game and keep up with technological advancements.

Q. How should the academia reinvent their curriculum to create techies suitable for the industry?

A. More than fifty per cent of India's population is below the age of 25, and the prediction is that, average age of an Indian by 2020 will be 29 years, compared to 37 for China and 48 for Japan. With this as the backdrop, we will witness a significant change in the demographics of India's working population. Hence, it is imperative for a transformational change in the curriculum so that the right skills are imparted to satisfy the thirst for knowledge of this increasingly dynamic group who are at the forefront of technology.

One way of transforming would be to focus on building on creative skills alongside basic life-skills to be more relevant and employable in the VUCA (volatile, uncertain, complex and ambiguous) world. A few universities have already made a head-start; others need to quickly follow.

Q. What steps can academic institutions take to bridge the industry-academia gap for the electronics design sector?

A. Curriculum shift is needed from conventional electronics to end-user-oriented design. In this increasingly connected world, practicalities of ensuring knowledge imparted should be more on covering a wide range of technology and solutions, keeping the curriculum responsive and relevant in connecting complex industries.

Q. What are the key technology skillsets that are being sought?

A. One of the best places to be

right now is the electronics industry. We are riding an exciting wave at this point with the IoT playing a huge part of this change. Technology component distributors are here to support and grow this new business if one covers the entire ecosystem from design to mass production.

Our industry continues to be niche and dynamic and, hence, we look for candidates who are not just electronics engineers but also have a flair for the ABC—artificial intelligence (AI), Big Data and cloud—of technology.

Q. How do you mainly hire—through campus recruitment or direct?

A. Avnet has a vast potential for self-marketing for filling in key positions. However, we believe that our best brand ambassadors are our employees since they understand our business, culture and the organisation from close quarters and, hence, we also rely on internal referrals.

Q. Do you prefer IITians or MTech/MBA holders, or do you hire from Tier 2 and 3 colleges, too?

A. Our focus is not on pedigree alone. We look for assertive, creative and enthusiastic individuals who can demonstrate the same on the field. Our objective is to meet the expectations of our customers and add value to the ecosystem that we support.

Q. Any unique hiring practice followed at Avnet to get the right candidate?

A. Though Avnet is an almost hundred-year-old company, we embrace new markets, new processes and new technology fast within the technology distribution fraternity. This is true because of our people. We place values ahead of skills, and our hiring managers are well-equipped to identify these demonstrated behaviours. **EFY**